“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 8

The Reduction of the Meals

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I worship Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, who, out of fear of Rāmacandra Purī, reduced His own meals below the ordinary measure.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya, the descent of the ocean of mercy, whose feet Brahmā, Śiva and the other gods worship!

3 Glory, glory to Śrīvāsa and to all the devotees, whose life’s treasure is the Lord, Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya![2]

4 In this way Gauracandra enjoyed His pastimes in Nīlācala with His own devotees, amid the waves of love for Kṛṣṇa.

5 At that time Rāmacandra Purī Gosāñi came and met Paramānanda Purī and the Lord.[3]

6 Paramānanda Purī paid homage at his feet, and Purī Gosāñi embraced him firmly.

7 Mahāprabhu offered him prostrate obeisance; he embraced the Lord and remembered Kṛṣṇa.[4]

8 For some time the three of them spoke together about the Lord. Then Jagadānanda Paṇḍita invited him for a meal.

9 Jagadānanda brought Jagannātha's prasāda for the meal, and Rāmacandra Purī ate as much as he liked, only to find fault afterwards.[5]

10 When he had eaten, the Purī said, "Listen, Jagadānanda: you eat the prasāda that remains."

11 He insisted on seating Jagadānanda and feeding him, and eagerly served the food himself.

12 Again and again he pressed him to eat; and when Jagadānanda had rinsed his mouth, he began to find fault:

13 "I had heard that Caitanya's followers eat a great deal. That report is true: now I have seen it with my own eyes.

14 Feeding a sannyāsī so much, they ruin his dharma; and though they are renunciants, they eat so much that they have not even a semblance of renunciation!"[6]

15 This was his nature: first he would insist on feeding someone a great deal, and afterwards he would find fault with him.

16 Formerly, when Mādhavendra Purī was departing from this world, Rāmacandra Purī came to him.[7]

17 Purī Gosāñi was chanting the name of Kṛṣṇa and weeping: "I have not attained Mathurā!"[8]

18 Then Rāmacandra Purī instructed him. Though a disciple, he spoke to his guru without fear:

19 “You are full of the bliss of Brahman — remember it! You are a knower of Brahman: why do you weep?”[9]

20 Hearing this, Mādhavendra Purī grew angry. “Away, away, you sinner!” he cried, and rebuked him.[10]

21 “I have not attained Kṛṣṇa’s mercy, I have not attained Mathurā. I am leaving this world in my own grief, and now this one has come to add to my burning pain!

22 Never show me your face again; go wherever you like! If I leave this world while looking at you, I shall come to an evil end.

23 I am leaving this world in my own grief, not having attained Kṛṣṇa, and now this wretched fool would teach me about Brahman!”

24 Śrī Mādhavendrapāda thus disregarded him, and through that offence worldly desires (*vāsanā*) were born in Rāmacandra Purī.[11]

25 A dry knower of Brahman, he had no relationship with Kṛṣṇa. He found fault with everyone and stubbornly persisted in it.[12]

26 Īśvara Purī, however, served Śrīpāda Mādhavendra Purī, cleaning away his stool and urine with his own hands.[13]

27 He constantly helped him remember the name of Kṛṣṇa, and at every moment let him hear Kṛṣṇa’s name and Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes.

28 Pleased with him, Purī Gosāñi embraced him and gave him a blessing: “May you have the treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa!”

29 From then on Īśvara Purī was an ocean of love, while Rāmacandra Purī became one who found fault with everyone.

30 The two of them are witnesses of a great soul’s mercy and punishment; through these two he taught the people of the world.[14]

31 Having given the gift of love, Mādhavendra, the guru of the world, recited this verse and departed from this world:

32 “O Lord, melting with compassion for the wretched! O Lord of Mathurā, when shall I see You? My heart, stricken at not seeing You, has lost all rest. O Beloved, what am I to do?” (Padyāvalī, 330)[15]

33 This verse teaches love for Kṛṣṇa — the special feeling (*bhāva-viśeṣa*) a devotee knows in separation from Him.[16]

34 He planted the sprout of love on the earth and departed. Śrī Caitanya Ṭhākura is the tree that grew from that sprout of love.[17]

35 In this context I have told of Purī Gosāñi’s departure from this world. Whoever hears of it is greatly fortunate.[18]

36 So Rāmacandra Purī stayed on in Nīlācala. Renounced by nature, he would stay now in one place, now in another.[19]

37 He took his meals uninvited, with no fixed rule, and he kept account of how others took their meals.[20]

38 To invite the Lord for a meal cost four paṇas of cowries, for sometimes Kāśīśvara and Govinda ate as well, three persons in all.[21]

39 Every day the Lord took His meal at one place or another. If someone brought money for it, the amount was fixed at four paṇas.

40 Rāmacandra Purī inquired into everything about the Lord: where He stayed, His ways, His meals, His sleep and His going out.

41 He could not grasp a single one of the Lord's virtues. He went about seeking faults, but found none anywhere.

42 "He is a sannyāsī, yet He eats sweets! With such enjoyment, how can there be control of the senses?"

43 Finding this fault, he spoke of it before everyone; and yet he came every day to see the Lord.

44 Regarding him as a guru, the Lord showed him reverence and honour, but he went about looking for faults — that was his occupation.

45 The Lord knew all the fault-finding he did, yet He still treated him with great respect and reverence.

46 One morning he came to the Lord's house. Seeing ants there, he made a remark:

47 "Last night there was sugarcane molasses here; that is why the ants are crawling about. Alas! Such is the craving of the senses in renounced sannyāsīs!" Saying this, he got up and left.[22]

48 The Lord had heard of his fault-finding through others; now He heard the invented blame with His own ears.[23]

49 Ants naturally wander about everywhere, yet he raised an argument from it and attached a fault to the Lord.

50 Hearing this, the Lord felt embarrassment and fear in His mind. He called Govinda and spoke to him:[24]

51 “From today this is the rule for My meals: a quarter-pot of the rice offered on Jagannātha’s altar (*piṇḍā-bhoga*), and vegetables worth five gaṇḍās.[25]

52 Take nothing more than this. If you bring more, you will not see Me here again.”

53 Govinda told all the Vaiṣṇavas this news. Hearing it, they felt as if a thunderbolt had struck their heads.

54 Everyone reproached Rāmacandra Purī: “This sinner has come here and taken the life of us all!”

55–56 That day a brāhmaṇa invited the Lord. Govinda accepted only a quarter-pot of rice and vegetables worth five gaṇḍās, and the brāhmaṇa struck his head and cried out in grief.

57 The Lord ate half of the rice and vegetables, and whatever remained Govinda received.

58 The Lord ate half a meal and Govinda half a meal, and then all the devotees gave up eating.[26]

59 The Lord ordered Govinda and Kāśīśvara, “You two beg elsewhere and fill your stomachs.”

60 Some days passed in this great grief. Hearing of it, Rāmacandra Purī came to the Lord.

61 The Lord bowed down and paid homage at his feet, and the Purī, smiling, spoke to the Lord:[27]

62 “A sannyāsī’s dharma is not to gratify the senses. He just fills his stomach somehow or other.[28]

63 I see that You have grown thin, and I hear You eat only half Your meals. This dry renunciation is not a sannyāsī’s dharma.

64 When he fills his stomach as is fitting and does not enjoy sense objects, then a sannyāsī’s *jñāna-yoga* is perfected.

65 ‘O Arjuna, there is no yoga for one who eats too much, nor for one who does not eat at all, nor for one given to too much sleep, nor for one who stays awake too long.’ (Bhagavad-gītā, 6.16)

66 ‘For one who is regulated in eating and recreation, regulated in his efforts at work, and regulated in sleep and waking, yoga becomes the destroyer of all sorrow.’” (Bhagavad-gītā, 6.17)

67 The Lord said, “I am an ignorant boy, your disciple. That you instruct Me is My good fortune.”[29]

68 Hearing this, Rāmacandra Purī got up and left. The Gosāñi heard that the devotees were eating only half their meals.

69 On another day Paramānanda Purī, with the devotees, humbly and courteously submitted to the Lord:

70 "Rāmacandra Purī has the nature of a fault-finder. What will be gained by giving up food at his word?[30]

71 It is the Purī's nature to make people eat as much as they like; and if someone will not eat, he takes great pains to feed him.

72 Having fed him, he then finds fault with him: 'You eat so much food — how much wealth do you have?

73 By feeding a sannyāsī so much, you ruin his dharma! Now I see that you have not even a semblance of piety.'[31]

74 He is always inquiring into how each person behaves and how each one eats.

75 The two things that the scriptures forbid are what he does constantly.

76 'One should neither praise nor blame the nature and actions of others, but see the universe as one, a union of prakṛti and the puruṣa.' (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.28.1)[32]

77 Of the two, he gives up the earlier injunction, praise, and practises the later one, blame, knowing that the later one is 'stronger'.[33]

78 'Between an earlier and a later injunction, the later injunction is stronger.' (a maxim of Nyāya)[34]

79 Where there are a hundred virtues he accepts none of them; instead he deceitfully imputes faults to those very virtues.

80 It is not fitting even to speak of his nature. Still I tell You something of it, for it pains us to the heart.[35]

81 Why do You give up food at his word? Accept invitations as before and heed the request of us all."

82 The Lord said, "Why are you all angry with the Purī? He speaks the natural dharma of a sannyāsī. What fault is there in him?

83 For a renunciant to be greedy of the tongue is very improper. A renunciant's dharma is to eat only as much food as keeps him alive."[36]

84 Then all of them together entreated the Lord earnestly, and at everyone's insistence the Lord agreed to take half of His former measure.

85 To invite the Lord now cost two paṇas of cowries. Sometimes two persons ate, sometimes three.

86 If a brāhmaṇa whose cooked food could not be accepted invited the Lord, two paṇas of cowries were needed to buy prasāda.

87 If a brāhmaṇa whose cooked food could be accepted invited Him, he would bring some prasāda and cook some at home.

88 But when Paṇḍita Gosāñi, Bhagavān Ācārya or Sārvabhauma invited Him,[37]

89 the Lord ate as they wished. In their homes He had no independence: all was as they desired.

90 The Lord descended to give happiness to His devotees, and He acted as was fitting in each place and situation.[38]

91 Sometimes He followed worldly ways, like an ordinary person; sometimes, being independent, He displayed His divine majesty (*aiśvarya*).[39]

92 Sometimes He was almost like a servant of Rāmacandra Purī; sometimes He paid him no regard and looked on him as a straw.[40]

93 The Lord's divine conduct is beyond the reach of the intellect. Whatever He does, at whatever time, is wholly enchanting.[41]

94 In this way Rāmacandra Purī stayed some days in Nīlācala and then left on pilgrimage.

95 When he had gone, the Lord's associates were delighted, as if a stone had suddenly fallen from their heads.

96 Freely the Lord again accepted invitations and freely He sang kīrtana and danced; freely everyone again ate prasāda.

97 When the guru disregards someone, such is the result: gradually he comes to offend even the Lord.[42]

98 Regarding him as a guru, the Lord did not hold his faults against him; yet through the fruit they bore He taught the people.[43]

99 Śrī Caitanya's conduct is like a flood of nectar; when heard, it is sweet to the ears and to the mind.

100 I write of Śrī Caitanya's conduct: hear it with undivided attention, and you will easily attain love for the feet of Śrī Kṛṣṇa.

101 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.[44]

Notes

1. Heading in the edition: obeisance to the Lord, who out of fear of Rāmacandra Purī reduced His meals. *Anubhāṣya*: this fear was outward and worldly, roused by the words of Rāmacandra Purī, a blasphemer of Hari, the guru and the Vaiṣṇavas; the Lord's meals were moderate even before, yet He cut them below the measure people consider ordinary. ↩
2. The first line is the same as Ādi 8.4; translated as there. The *Anubhāṣya* gives here another reading of two verses: "Glory, glory to Nityānanda, the moon among avadhūtas, who bound the world with the noose of prema! Glory, glory to Śrī Advaita, the descent of Īśvara, who called Kṛṣṇa down and delivered the world!" ↩
3. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Rāmacandra Purī was a disciple of Śrī Mādhavendra Purī, and so Mahāprabhu and Paramānanda Purī honoured him. *Anubhāṣya*: by nature he was envious and hostile to Hari, the guru and the Vaiṣṇavas, but he wore the dress of a sannyāsī, and only for that did people call him "Gosāñi": in those days the title was given to those who had left home, not by caste or birth. ↩
4. *Anubhāṣya*: taking Mahāprabhu for a follower of Īśvara Purī, Rāmacandra Purī embraced Him and remembered Kṛṣṇa, as is customary among Vaiṣṇava sannyāsīs: when greeted, they reply "*oṁ namo bhagavate nārāyaṇāya*"; a sannyāsī is not to bless living beings or bow to them. ↩
5. Heading in the edition: having eaten more than his fill, he blames the one who feeds him. ↩
6. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *bhāsa* — at least a semblance (*ābhāsa*). Heading in the edition: he blames the associates of Gaura, truly endowed with pure renunciation, as if they lacked it. ↩
7. Heading in the edition: the past of Rāmacandra Purī, rejected by his guru; he comes when his gurudeva, Śrī Mādhavendra Purī, is departing from this world. ↩
8. Heading in the edition: Śrī Mādhavendra Purī chants of Kṛṣṇa in the transcendental rasa of separation (*vipralambha*). ↩
9. Heading in the edition: Rāmacandra opposes the spiritual pastimes (*cid-vilāsa*). ↩
10. *Anubhāṣya*: Mādhavendra Purī was suffering in separation from Kṛṣṇa — transcendental *vipralambha* had appeared in him; but Rāmacandra, reasoning in a worldly way and taking his guru for a mortal, thought he grieved over some worldly want and hastened to bring him to the realisation of impersonal

Brahman. Seeing the folly of his disciple and his disrespect for the guru, Mādhavendra Purī rejected him and drove him away. ↩

11. Heading in the edition: from the offence of disrespect for the guru arises the desire for sense enjoyment, that is, worldly desires. The *Anubhāṣya* quotes the *Bhagavat-pariśiṣṭa*: even those liberated in this life fall back into worldly desires if they offend the Lord. The *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* explains *vāsanā* otherwise — as the desire for dry knowledge, from which blasphemy of the devotees is born. ↩
12. *Anubhāṣya*: *nirbandha* — a stubborn attachment to blaming others. Impersonalists, weak in the knowledge of one's relationship with the Lord (*sambandha-jñāna*), cannot accept a relationship with Kṛṣṇa and blame the devotees and their service; a soul falls into such ignorance when he offends the feet of the guru or of a devotee. ↩
13. Śrī Īśvara Purī is the Guru of Mahāprabhu. *Anubhāṣya*: *śrīpāda-sevana* — service to Śrī Mādhavendra Purīpāda. Heading in the edition: the undivided devotion of Śrīla Īśvara Purī to his guru. ↩
14. *Anubhāṣya*: from the great soul, Śrīla Mādhavendra Purī, Īśvara Purī received abundant mercy (*anugraha*), and Rāmacandra Purī only punishment (*nigraha*). ↩
15. The same verse as Madhya 4.197; translated as there. Here it is spoken by Mādhavendra Purī himself. The source follows the heading in the edition of this chapter: "the words of Mādhavendra Purī, given in the *Padyāvalī* as number 330" (the heading to Madhya 4.197 gives number 400); the *Anubhāṣya* refers to Madhya 4.197. Heading in the edition (to 31): Mādhavendra Gosvāmī departs from the manifest world in the transcendental state of separation. ↩
16. *Anubhāṣya*: *bhāva-viśeṣa* — the manifestation of the feeling of separation (*vipralambha*). Among the *prākṛta-sahajiyās*, practitioners commit all kinds of excesses in the name of *sambhoga* (union) and so obstruct the realisation of the true nature of separation. ↩
17. Heading in the edition: Mādhavendra is the sprout of the wish-fulfilling tree of love for Kṛṣṇa; Śrī Caitanya Himself is the main tree, grown from that sprout and spread wide. ↩
18. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *niryāṇa* — departure from the manifest world (*aprakaṭa*). Heading in the edition: hearing of Mādhavendra's departure, living beings learn the service born of separation from Kṛṣṇa. ↩
19. Heading in the edition: the dry renunciation of Rāmacandra Purī. ↩
20. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: he found out how others took their meals — what and how much they ate. *Anubhāṣya*: he spent his days keeping account of

where another sannyāsī took alms, how much, where he lived and so on. ↩

21. A paṇa is eighty cowries. Heading in the edition: how the Lord took His meals each day; with Him ate Govinda and Kāśīśvara, disciples of Śrī Īśvara Purī. ↩
22. *Aikṣava* — molasses from sugarcane (*Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*). *Anubhāṣya*: Mahāprabhu is Bhagavān Himself, beyond all material qualities; finding no flaw in Him and seeing no sweets in His house, Rāmacandra guessed from the ants that molasses had been there at night, so as to mention some flaw and thereby exalt himself. ↩
23. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *kalpita nindana* — a falsely imputed charge. ↩
24. *Anubhāṣya*: hearing Himself blamed, the Lord, in the role of ācārya, the guru of the world, feels fear and shame. ↩
25. *Anubhāṣya*: Jagannātha's prasāda — rice — is received in earthen pots; a quarter of a pot of the usual measure is called *ek-cauṭhi*. A gaṇḍā is four cowries. ↩
26. The Lord ate half of the appointed quarter-pot, and Govinda the rest (57). Heading in the edition (to 57): the devotees give up food and drink. ↩
27. Heading in the edition: the Lord, in the role of an ācārya who gives honour to others (*mānada*), always honours Rāmacandra. ↩
28. Heading in the edition: he teaches the Lord the dharma of a renunciant (*yati-dharma*). ↩
29. Heading in the edition: the Lord's humble words — an example of the dharma of one who seeks no honour (*amānī*). ↩
30. Heading in the edition (to 69): the devotees headed by Paramānanda Purī ask the Lord to take the proper measure of food and censure before Him the nature and conduct of Rāmacandra Purī. ↩
31. *Bhāsa* — "a semblance, a shadow" (*Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* to 14), as in 14: there is not even a semblance of dharma in you. ↩
32. *Ekātmakam* — "one in nature" (*Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*). *Anubhāṣya*: thus Śrī Bhagavān describes to Uddhava the conduct of a pure jñānī; the verse speaks of praise and blame of the nature and acts of others meant to harm them. ↩
33. *Anubhāṣya*: in verse 76 the earlier injunction is "do not praise", the later "do not blame"; the later is stronger, so praising people is no great sin, but blaming them must be avoided at all costs. Rāmacandra kept the earlier and not the later; the verse may be read as mockery. ↩
34. The source follows the heading in the edition: "a maxim of Nyāya" (*nyāya-vacana*). ↩

35. The Gauḍīya Maṭha edition reads *iṅhā kahite*, “to speak of this” (another reading: *iṅhā karite*, “to act so”). *Anubhāṣya*: *pāya* — “having felt” (the heart’s pain). ↩
36. Heading in the edition (to 82): the Lord, guru of the world and teacher of the people, sets down the rules of the renunciant’s dharma; though He is Īśvara Himself, He regards Himself as a jīva bound by the rules of renunciation and teaches detachment. ↩
37. Heading in the edition: Bhagavān, subject to His devotees, eats in the homes of Gadādhara, Bhagavān Ācārya and Sārvabhauma. ↩
38. Heading in the edition: the purpose of the Lord’s descent and the way He acts. ↩
39. Heading in the edition: sometimes the Lord behaves like a worldly jīva and so deceives, and sometimes, as the Supreme Lord, He bestows full mercy. ↩
40. Heading in the edition: sometimes He shows Rāmacandra Purī worldly honour, and sometimes He holds him of no account. ↩
41. Heading in the edition: all that the inconceivable Īśvara does is eternal, beneficial and beautiful. ↩
42. Heading in the edition: when, for disrespect towards the guru, the guru disregards a jīva, the fruit is enmity towards Viṣṇu, that is, godlessness (*pāṣaṇḍatā*). ↩
43. *Anubhāṣya*: through the conduct of the offender Rāmacandra the Lord teaches the world. ↩
44. The colophon verse is the same as Antya 2.172; translated as there. ↩